

THE INDIAN MASSACRE OF THE
CAPUCHINS IN TRINIDAD IN 1699:
A FACTOR IN TRINIDAD'S ECONOMIC STAGNATION

RECOGNISING the failure to assimilate the Trinidad Indians to Spanish culture, the king of Spain in 1686 asked the Capuchin Order to undertake a mission to Trinidad so that the "Indians may learn to live a quiet and civilized life."¹ Eight Capuchin priests under Fr. Thomas de Barcelona arrived in 1687 and founded four missions; two in Naparima, one in San Fernando, and one in Savana Grande. They built their villages following a uniform plan: "A perfect square is traced on the ground and all the Indian ajoupas are built on three sides, north, south, and west of the streets . . . the eastern side of the mission is taken up by the church, the mission house and other buildings for the use of the priests."²

Well supported by the authorities in Spain and in Trinidad, these Indian missions soon proved to be a successful experiment. The Indians were required to remain in the missions for ten years. For the first four days of the week they worked for the mission, the next two on their own provision grounds, and on Sunday they rested. In exchange for providing free labour, they received board and protection from the missionaries. This form of serfdom was voluntary and anyone was free to leave the mission. Indeed, it was reported that several returned "to the forests to continue their idolatrous practices."³ Permission was given to the missionaries to distribute Indians for monthly service on other plantations at a wage of 16 reales each. But, the successful growth of cocoa on the mission plantations absorbed all the Indians and incurred the resentment of the Spanish planters who, as a result, experienced a scarcity of labour. Thanks to the Capuchin missionaries, cocoa had become the backbone of the economy and Trinidad was for the first time approaching prosperity.

The mission was, to a degree, a successful social experiment. On the one hand, cocoa made the mission self sufficient. On the other hand, the Indians lived in peace, amply protected both from the European adventurers and the more warlike Indians. One must hasten to add, however, that some were not contented: "Worn out with continual labour, they

¹ C. R. Ottley, *Spanish Trinidad* (Trinidad: Longman, 1971), p. 28.

² *Ibid.*, p. 31.

³ *Ibid.*, p. 32.

regard the proposals to convert them as a snare . . . for the purpose of making them work."⁴

On December 1, 1699, Fr. Esteban de San Felice, Fr. Marcos de Vique, Fray Ramón de Figuerola and a Dominican, Fr. Juan Marián de Sotomayor were murdered by the Indians of the mission of San Francisco de la Arena. The Governor, José de León y Echales, and his party were ambushed that very day on their way to visit that mission. All but the Sergeant Major, Manuel Fermín, who returned badly wounded, were killed. On December 3, Don Pedro Fernandez de la Vega and a party of 30 set out to investigate what had happened. On reaching the river Aripo, which was about 5 miles from the capital, St. Joseph, they found some dead bodies. They were unable to cross the swollen river to reach the mission of Arena and returned to the capital. On December 5, 40 men set out for the mission. They found the murdered missionaries, the church disarranged, the eyes of the statues destroyed, and the noses broken. Fray Ramón de Figuerola was lying in a wooden enclosure, and the others in the pit which was dug to prepare the foundation for a new building.⁵ They decided to continue towards the coast, hoping to come upon the Indians who were responsible for the atrocities. On December 6, they encountered a group of Indians and gave no quarter. Rather than surrender, the Indians threw themselves into the sea and were shot. Two Indian women were captured and forced to reveal where the other Indians were. Continuing the pursuit into the swamp, they captured only two men.

On December 18, the captured Indian men and women were brought to trial. Asked whether he knew that it was a great crime to kill the mission fathers, the Indian, Pedro, answered that he did not and admitted that 3 Indians, Bustamante, Lucas, and Sebastian killed the missionaries between 9 and 10 a.m. on December 1, stripped them, placed ropes around their necks, dragged them and then buried them head first in the pits dug for the new church. Then they went, he continued, to the Calle Real to wait in ambush for the governor. Between 3 and 4 p.m. they ambushed the party, killing all including 2 Negroes who were with the party. Then they returned to the mission where they destroyed everything in the kitchen, broke the statues, putting out the eyes of St. Francis and breaking the fingers and the nose of the Virgin of the Rosary.⁶ Explaining why such a deed was committed, the other Indian, Luis, gave as the reason their fear of the governor who had a few days before punished the Indians of

⁴ *Ibid.*

⁵ P. J. Buissink, ed., *The Arena Massacre, Trinidad. Documents relating to the massacre. General Archives of the Indies, Seville, Audiencia of Santo Domingo, 582* (Trinidad, 1938), pp. 26-36.

⁶ *Ibid.*, pp. 37-38.

the missions of Naparima, Savana Grande and Savaneta for sorcery and for actions unbecoming Catholic doctrine. Testifying on behalf of the Indians, Antonio de Bustamante, protector of the Indians, declared that the two were not directly guilty of the crime and asked the court for clemency. The prosecutor, however, demanded exemplary punishment, and, according to Spanish legal practice, asked the accused to ratify their statements. They added that they were caught on their way to the mission of Savaneta to warn the Indians there "so that the white people would not deceive them and hang the old people."⁷ Pedro and Luis were sentenced to be hanged and the two women to 6 years of personal service for the captains who had captured them.

On January 1, 1700, Don Antonio de la Cruz, general of the Naparima Indians, brought back 84 Indian prisoners. A general meeting was held and it was proposed that all men over 14 years be hanged and the rest be distributed to people in the town for service. From the testimony of the Indians at the trial, the reasons for the massacre seem clear. Evidently the missionaries had reprimanded the Indians for not assisting in the construction of the new church and participating in the instruction classes, and then threatened to report them to the governor who had recently punished Indians on other missions. On the night before the massacre, the Indians held a meeting at which it was decided to commit these murders. The Indian, Pablo, admitted that he alone killed Fray Ramón de Figueroa who had been locked in a little room by another Indian, that he broke down the door with an axe and killed Fray Ramón as he stood with "a holy Christ in his hands."⁸ The testimony of each Indian was remarkably similar, each attesting that he did participate in the massacre but that two of the accused, Calisto and Ignacio, were innocent. It seems that Ignacio was not present and Calisto was sick at the time of the massacre. Twenty two were condemned to be hanged publicly: "After their death their hands and heads shall be cut off and exposed and nailed in the places where they committed their crime, and their bodies shall be cut in pieces and put along the roads for their punishment and good example of the public vengeance."⁹ Ignacio was sentenced to two years of personal service in the Capuchin convent and Calisto to four years of exile in the royal fortress of Arouca.

The lesson of the massacre and trial surely is that the Spanish attempt to make the Indians live like Spaniards had not succeeded as late as 1699. What emerged from the trial was that some Indians were still ob-

⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 54.

⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 7.

⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 15.

serving their own religion although the Spaniards might call it sorcery. If one considers that these Indians had already been under the influence of the missionaries for some time, then the massacre implied a rejection by some of Christianity and of Spanish culture.

On August 12, 1701, the priests of St. Joseph, some members of the Town Council with soldiers and guides went to the site of the massacre to bring back the remains of the victims and were amazed to find the bodies uncorrupted and their blood still red as if the wounds were recent. The bodies were placed in different coffins, taken back to St. Joseph, and exposed in the church for nine days without showing signs of decomposition. Crowds assembled from all parts of the island. After nine days, the bodies were buried in the Parish church.¹⁰

The massacre had unfortunate repercussions for the Capuchin priests. It gave the Spanish planters much-needed ammunition in their case against the missions. They argued that the Indians revolted because they were idle; they suggested that since the missionaries had already converted the Indians to Catholicism they should be forced to release them from the missions so that they could work on the plantations. The king of Spain heeded their complaints and, on August 15, 1708, decreed that the missionaries had rights over the Indians only in religious matters. Moreover, he proposed that they should concentrate their missionary efforts elsewhere since their task of bringing peace to the island was completed. Disappointed, most of them returned to Spain.¹¹

Trinidad under Spanish rule (1498-1797) was for the most part neglected. Its importance as a strategic base owing to its proximity to the famed el Dorado in Guyana ended with the disillusionment of Sir Walter Raleigh and Antonio de Berrio over the existence of el Dorado. The Capuchin mission was the first genuine Spanish attempt to colonize Trinidad in a civilized manner. And it might have succeeded were it not for the caprice of the Spanish planters and the insensibility of the Spanish sovereign. The promise of Trinidad at the turn of the eighteenth century was not realized. The cocoa trees were stricken by disease and no remedy was found. By 1733 the island returned to a subsistence economy; the Indians fled once more to the forests, and the population dwindled to a mere 150 whites and mulattoes and 150 Blacks. The Capuchin Order was clearly responsible for its first period of prosperity and their departure from the colony, due in no small measure to the massacre, was certainly one of the causes of its decline.

¹⁰ Mateo de Anguiano, *Misión apostólica. Pueblo de los Arenales* (Madrid, 1702), pp. 1-16.

¹¹ Ottley, *op. cit.*, p. 41.

But the memory of the massacre of the Capuchin Fathers did not end in total oblivion. On November 6, 1885, Fr. Bertrand Cothoway, who was sent to preach a retreat for first Communion in Tumpuna, persuaded a 60 year old Indian to lead him to the spot where the Capuchin Fathers were killed.¹² He was taken to an Indian village and enquired of the chief if he had heard of a place where some priests had been killed. The chief, whose grandparents had come from Venezuela after the war of independence, replied that he did and offered to take him there. He said the place was well known by the Indians, who at various times during the year went to pray at this place. Ironically, it was the Indians who had preserved the memory of the martyrs. When they arrived, Fr. Bertrand found bits of broken bottles and plates which he felt was ample evidence that that was the site of the massacre: "I had sufficient proofs that I was indeed on the spot hallowed by the blood of martyrs. Immediately kneeling, I invoked the glorious apostles of Trinidad who had come here when times, though still difficult, were different."¹³ In response to a petition by Fr. Bertrand, the government of Trinidad granted a few acres of land in 1886 to make the site a place of prayers and pilgrimage. No chapel was built through lack of funds and the idea seemed to die until October 10, 1937, when His Excellency the Governor of Trinidad, Sr. A. C. Hollis visited the site and was convinced that something should be done to preserve the memory of the Trinidad martyrs. Official help was not asked and, with funds donated from England, Australia, France, Canada, the United States, Belgium, and Holland, a small chapel was built.¹⁴ The chapel attracted several pilgrims from all over the island. Today the chapel is in ruins and although it is much easier to get there than in Fr. Bertrand's time, it attracts neither the religious nor the curious.

DAVID M. TRABOULAY

Staten Island Community College
City University of New York

¹² P. Bertrand Cothonay, *Trinidad, journal d'un missionnaire dominicain* (Paris, 1898), pp. 359-368.

¹³ *Ibid.*

¹⁴ Archives of the Parish Church of San Rafael. Uncatalogued and unpaginated.